

Counterfactual Forks Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	counterfactual-forks

Big idea: Counterfactual thinking can clarify causation when it is disciplined by evidence.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students build careful counterfactuals to test causal claims without turning history into fantasy.

Student Prompt

Inspect Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: School example: What if the viral incident had not happened, but earlier complaints still existed?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Counterfactual Forks Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Historical prompt: What if one reform law had failed, while economic and social pressures remained?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Counterfactual Forks Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Historical prompt: What if one reform law had failed, while economic and social pressures remained?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Counterfactual thinking can clarify causation when it is disciplined by evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Counterfactual Forks Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Can historians know what did not happen?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how counterfactual thinking can clarify causation when it is disciplined by evidence.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can historians know what did not happen?

Setup Checklist

- Choose a causal story where one small change is plausible.
- Keep students close to evidence by requiring a constraint card for every counterfactual.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- School example: What if the viral incident had not happened, but earlier complaints still existed?
- Historical prompt: What if one reform law had failed, while economic and social pressures remained?

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/counterfactual-forks/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/counterfactual-forks/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/counterfactual-forks/visual-prompt.svg>
- Counterfactual fork sheet: changed condition, fixed constraints, likely effects, uncertainty.
- Plausibility checklist: available actors, resources, beliefs, institutions, timing.

Run Sequence

1. Choose one historical event or school-history scenario with several causes.
2. Students identify one plausible turning point.
3. Groups change one condition while keeping other constraints realistic.
4. Students predict what would likely, possibly, and unlikely change.
5. Debrief how counterfactuals can test causal claims.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Can historians know what did not happen?
- When do counterfactuals clarify causation and when do they become fantasy?
- How do evidence and plausibility constrain historical imagination?

Teacher Quick Script

- A disciplined counterfactual changes one thing and respects the rest of the evidence.
- What does your fork reveal about causal importance?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...